

**With reference to the assigned videos and reading, what mantra(s) will guide your writing this semester?**

After some thought, I believe I want my mantra for this semester to be a simple yet powerfully broad question: Why are you writing? Lorrie Moore's passage makes it clear that as a writer, you need to bring passion and creative direction into your writing, and that writing for the sake of writing will lead to shabby work. I think her passage is the perfect example of this - you feel her emotion and struggle as she describes her tortuous path of becoming a writer. The purpose of her writing was to inform us of why she chose her profession, and it was powerful because of that message. Writing was, as she called it, an unfortunate habit.

I believe the motto of "Why are you writing?" also ties into Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's talk. She details exactly how the stories we tell are a single view point of a subject, whether it be a country, a person, or an experience. Without knowing why I write, I cannot possibly begin to understand how my story will be perceived. I need to be conscious of the story I tell.

Finally, I think my question of "Why am I writing this?" is directly influenced by Roxane Gay's class expert. I will not lie, I had to rewatch the video because I forgot what she talked about after writing the first two paragraphs, and I was pleasantly surprised to find that it fits right in. She accurately claims that without a sense of purpose in your writing, the reader will be left questioning what they read, unable to digest the message you were trying to give them, if there was a message at all. She mirrors Adichie's message on a story's power to shape perceptions and views, and highlights the importance of having a clear vision set out before you begin your first words. I think the "Why" of your writing needs to incorporate the three appeals she details in the video, and that while writing *can* be done without them, good writing requires all three.